intelligence officers acknowledge this relationship, Khare, who knew its nuts-and-bolts, is categorical that India remains 'very close to the NDS'.[123] Though he denies that such links translate into joint offensive operations against Pakistan, the latter's allegation of a R&AW-NDS 'nexus', more broadly if not on specific operations, is accurate.

In 2004, a full-blown insurrection broke out in Balochistan with the Baloch Liberation Front (BLF, formerly known as the Baloch People's Liberation Front or the BPLF), the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA), and the Baloch Republican Party (BRP) undertaking attacks against the Pakistan army's installations. Nawab Akbar Khan Bugti, with support of his grandson Brahamdagh Bugti (among others), and Mir Balach Marri led the insurrection, and Musharraf openly blamed India and Afghanistan for fanning the insurgency.[124] Apart from harassing Pakistan, Indian motivations for the same were seen as linked to its geopolitical rivalry with China that began developing the Gwadar port in Balochistan. Promising to undermine India's naval and economic dominance and strengthening the China-Pakistan axis further, Gwadar's development is viewed with reservation in New Delhi.[125] Furthermore, China's policy of sending its nationals to build the port increased Baloch anxieties of becoming an exploited minority on their own land. These are powerful reasons for both India and the Baloch separatists to collaborate against China and Pakistan, if that ever happened.

There were nearly 500 Chinese nationals working at Gwadar in 2004 when the attacks on the Chinese and the Pakistan army began. On 3 May 2004, the BLA killed three Chinese engineers working on the port, and attacked the Gwadar airport on 21 May. Two Chinese engineers were kidnapped in October 2004 from South Waziristan, one of whom was later killed.[126] By December 2005 the violence had reached alarmingly high levels inviting official criticism by the MEA of Pakistan's heavy-handed counter-terrorism operations in Balochistan (eliciting angry ripostes from Islamabad).[127] Nambiar, in a meeting with the US ambassador to India in January 2006, assessed Islamabad's woes in Balochistan as a 'taste of their own medicine' similar to what India had been facing in Kashmir.[128] Whether this implied that India had adopted a similar strategy (to that of Pakistan in Kashmir) of supporting Baloch rebels covertly was left unsaid.